

Why Susanne K. Langer Needed Wittgenstein: An Early Challenge to Analytic Philosophy

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Abstract

Early analytic philosophy is often portrayed as progressing from the logical analysis of language toward the program of scientific philosophy associated with the Vienna Circle. Yet the philosophical landscape of the late 1920s and early 1930s was shaped by several intersecting developments, including Ludwig Wittgenstein's analysis of symbolic representation in the *Tractatus Logico-Philosophicus* and Ernst Cassirer's philosophy of symbolic forms. This paper examines a largely overlooked point of intersection between these traditions through the early work of Susanne K. Langer.

I argue that Wittgenstein plays a structural role in the architecture of Langer's *The Practice of Philosophy* (1930). His theory of symbolic representation provides the analytic foundation for her account of meaning. However, the trajectory of Langer's argument reveals a fundamental tension within the Tractarian framework: while logical symbolism is necessary for the analysis of meaning, it remains insufficient for accounting for symbolic understanding. In developing this point, Langer transforms the distinction between saying and showing into a broader theory of symbolic forms grounded in insight, Gestalt, and non-discursive modes of meaning.

By situating Langer within both the transatlantic reception of analytic philosophy and her intellectual engagement with Cassirer, the paper reconstructs her as a mediating figure between logical analysis and a more expansive philosophy of symbolism. Her work helps explain the notable interest it attracted among members of the Vienna Circle, while also revealing an alternative trajectory within early analytic philosophy—one in which the limits of formal analysis are not merely acknowledged but actively reworked.

Langer's engagement with Wittgenstein thus emerges as an early and systematic attempt to move beyond the Tractarian framework from within, anticipating later philosophical developments in which meaning and rationality are understood as embedded in broader symbolic and historically mediated practices.